

art -> installation

aka robustifying your work
aka making gallerists not hate you

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Leia (they/them)



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I'm Leia (they/them), a new media artist, creative technologist, and exhibit developer. I've been on the side of installing my own work as well as others', so here's a quick guide to making your work bit more robust.

installation basics

From 0 to 1

A lot of artists make incredible work, but that work is generated at home or at the studio. You control the scenario, you know how to interact with it, and it doesn't have to deal with the real world. Putting it in the public is ... a little different.

installation basics

From 0 to 1

show	timeline	what it's like
hackathon	<4 hours	you stand by the piece the whole time
showcase	1-3 days	you're still around to handle the piece, but maybe take breaks. it probably runs on your computer still
exhibition	3 days to 3 weeks	the turning point
selling work	forever	we're not gonna talk about this

First, Let's break down the kind of installations you'll (likely) do.

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"Exhibition" is where you stop babysitting your work, and hand it off to other people that will have to deal with it. This is the transition we'll talk about today, and how to think about it.

What's 0?

0 is ...

- a prototype! it works, but on your computer, and at max for like an hour
- it's held together by ... tape? hot glue?
- needs you to launch it



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Photo by Hugo Clément on [Unsplash](#)

0 is where you've all been, and where most of your work sits. It doesn't make sense to go much farther when you're testing things out, experimenting, and exploring. 0 is all the artwork up through proof of concept.

But then ... can you install your own, personal laptop at a gallery for 7 days?

What's 1?

1 is ...

- working on a **standalone computer** that will live in/at the installation site
- robust to light bumps, **structurally sound**, and is held together by nails, glue, or screws
- **launchable** in under 3 minutes by someone who is reading instructions off of a document
- essentially an **installable object**

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1 is what I would call *actually installable work*. You can put a 0 in a room and show it off, but won't fly at a gallery. 1 could live at a gallery, at least for a few days, without you babysitting it.



As an example, this is one of the first pieces of mine that I consider "installable". It has a functional body, is mildly sturdy, hides its hardware inside, and can just be plugged in and ready to go.

New Media Installable Objects



At the very least, you should have:

- A computer or other hardware dedicated to this piece, at least for the time period of the exhibition.
- A way to turn it on/off as needed.

If it's on a computer, it should be **auto-launching**. There's a bunch of ways of doing this.

- Mac: Automator
- Windows: Task Scheduler
- Linux: Startup Applications

Set your computers to auto-log-in, skip passwords, and avoid updates. Make sure the computer/hardware is *accessible* in case something goes wrong.

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Resource: there's a repo called [InstallationUp4Eva](#) that's a bit old, but is a great place to start. It has forks for Windows and Linux as well.

Installable New Media Object Checklist

- ☐ On a dedicated computer/hardware
- ☐ Can be turned off/on, muted, etc
- ☐ Auto-launches when powered on
- ☐ Structurally sound
- ☐ Internals can be accessed for repair

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(ok, but these three are actually the big ones).

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Want to be the gallerist's favorite artist?Get all of the above right, *and*

- ☐ Brightness, volume, or other states can be adjusted
- ☐ It can be moved and reassembled quickly
- ☐ Bring extra equipment! Extension cords, backup batteries, gaff tape.
- ☐ It's easy to debug if something goes wrong

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Each space will be different! If you can provide brightness controls, volume controls, or other tweaks, that lets your work shine in the best light in whatever environment it's in.

It's inevitable that your work may need to be moved by someone who *isn't* you. Build enclosures that house all your hardware inside, and don't let wires or peripherals hang out in precarious places.

And something will always go wrong. Be extra prepared and provide debug instructions; this can be as easy as "Reboot it" (autolaunch is KEY), or as much as "hey here's how you'd change the wifi on it if you need to".

1

Exercise: 0->1

Take the piece you're working on (or one you've made before). Write out how you would install it **as is**, without changes.

Does it meet the checklist?

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Now take it from 0 to 1. List the changes you'd need to make, and how you'd make them.

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3

Proposing an Installation

Proposing an Installation

7

So when I usually teach this workshop, I'm teaching grad students who are just beginning their journey with art; I have to step them through the full experience of their work, have them think about how a person will actually interact with their work.

But **YOU** are all artists, who care deeply about that experience already.

3

include in your proposal ...

- what is it *actually*
- what does it need space-wise
- equipment you need provided
- maintenance requirements

So here's a basic way to think about how you should build your proposal:

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- maintenance requirements

What is it *actually*?

- Describe your piece FULLY. Is it a computer? A raspberry pi in a box? A painting with a light shining on it? A single flower rotating on a motor?

What does it need space-wise?

- Physical installation: Is it mounted from the ceiling? From a wall? Does it sit on the floor, or a pedestal, or a shelf?
- Environmental needs: Does it need to be in a lit area, or dark? Sound isolation?

Equipment you need provided

- Pedestals, lights, speakers, projection surfaces
- Access to power, wifi networks, or other digital infrastructure

Maintenance requirements

- Will someone need to refresh it? Charge something?
- Does it need to be stocked with materials, like paper or ink?
- How do you start/stop the piece?
- What should they do if something goes wrong?

3

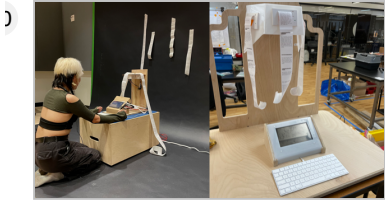
So how do you communicate all this?

So how do you communicate all this?

That's a lot to think about from your side. Your job is to get all of this information over to a curator/gallerist, who is looking at tens or hundreds of other proposals just like yours.

This is the same process I go through at work, from both sides.

Let's go through the process with something of mine.



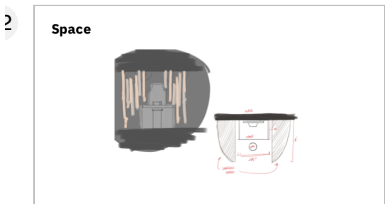
This is a piece of mine called In Our Own Words. I was pitching this installation for a showcase, and these two pictures are all I really had; a prototype of the experience (without the piece fabricated), and a piece that was probably 80% fabricated.

1

what is it	installation includes plywood altar with receipt printers, a raspberry pi, keyboard, and screen. surrounding archive is a series of hanging receipts
space needs	placed against a wall, with hanging/rigging capability. audience is seated or kneeling; 4+ ft of hanging room around the altar
equipment	installation requires power. spotlight lighting would be nice!
maintenance	turn on/off with a switch in the back, will auto-boot, replace receipt paper as needed (provided)

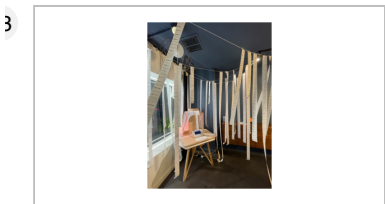
Here's what I gave the organizers.

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This was a quick sketch of the install that I wanted, with a couple of key things: the size of the sculpture and **the space that was needed around it.**

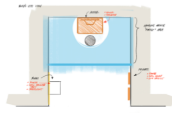
Space



Here's how that looked in-situ.

This was the second iteration of showing this ... it's a bit sloppy, but it kept to the idea that I'd proposed.

4

Flow

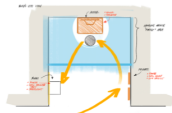
Birds-eye layout of installation

Flow

Birds-eye layout of installation

This is the initial sketch I sent in.

5

Flow

Birds-eye layout of installation

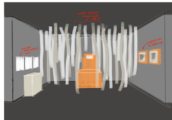
Flow

Birds-eye layout of installation

And the flow that I imagined people would go through to experience this.

This helps the gallerist understand the way I'd like visitors to approach the work, and make their own suggestions.

3

Vibe

Person-view of installation

Vibe

Person-view of installation

This is another sketch sent to give the curators an idea of what I was installing. First Person views are great if you can make them, but you can also make do by supplying plenty of photos and other sketches.

7



Installation at Gray Area SF

Installation at Gray Area SF

This is an installation I did for the Gray Area a few years ago. It was part of a "Showcase", which really meant it only was up for a few days, but the same show was installed at another venue for a month.

3

Exercise: the Proposal

Take the piece you're working on (or something you've made before). Think about **the whole experience** and write down everything you can about it.

what is it _____
 space needs _____
 equipment _____
 maintenance _____

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Have fun! Propose some stuff!
If you have questions you can ping me on ig *@leia.make*

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Hope that helps!